Your First Budget That Actually Sticks

7-Day Workbook System

A budget designed around your personality, not a spreadsheet you hate.

Name:	My #1 goal:
Date started:	Budget type (fill in after quiz):

Page 1 — The Permission Slip

Before you fill in a single number, read this.

You are not bad with money. You have been given bad tools.

Every budgeting app assumes you want to track 47 categories, check in daily, and feel guilty when you miss. That is not a system. That is a punishment.

This workbook works differently. It bends to your life. It matches your personality. It assumes you will have bad weeks and gives you a rescue plan for them.

The three rules of this system:

- Done beats perfect. A rough budget followed is worth more than a perfect one abandoned.
- Your personality is not a problem to fix. It is the input that makes this work.
- When life happens (and it will), Page 6 is waiting. No judgment, no starting over.

YOUR COMMITMENT (SIGN IT):

I commit to spending 10 minutes today on Pages 2 and 3. That is all.

Signed: _____ Date: _____

Page 2 — Your Budget Personality Quiz

Answer honestly. There is no wrong result. Circle or tick the answer that feels most true right now.

1. How often do you check your bank account?

- ☐ A Never — I prefer not to know
- ☐ B Once a month or when a bill is due
- ☐ C Weekly or more

2. When you overspend in a category, you usually...

- ☐ A Don't notice until the end of the month
- ☐ B Notice but keep spending anyway
- ☐ C Feel anxious and adjust immediately

3. Which statement sounds most like you?

- ☐ A Budgeting feels overwhelming so I avoid starting
- ☐ B I start budgets but break them for things I enjoy
- ☐ C I like having a plan but struggle when it's too rigid

4. When unexpected money comes in (bonus, tax refund), you usually...

- ☐ A Spend it before you make a plan
- ☐ B Spend part of it and save part without a clear split
- ☐ C Immediately decide where it goes

5. What has killed your budgets in the past?

- ☐ A I didn't know where to start
- ☐ B It felt like I couldn't spend on things I love
- ☐ C Real life didn't match the plan I made

Mostly A = The Avoider	Mostly B = The Spender	Mostly C = The Planner
Use Template C. Your system is built for simplicity first.	Use Template B. Fun money is built in — not an afterthought.	Use Template A. You want detail — this gives it to you.

MY BUDGET TYPE:

Write your result here:

Page 3 — Your Numbers (the only math you do)

Fill in the four boxes below. The system does the rest.

Monthly take-home income	*After tax, the amount that lands in your account each month.* **$**
Total fixed expenses	*Rent/mortgage, car, insurance, phone, subscriptions. Things that don't change.* **$**
My #1 financial goal	*e.g. Save $500 by July / Pay off Visa / Build emergency fund*
Monthly goal savings amount	*How much per month to hit that goal? Divide the total by months remaining.* **$**

Your breathing room number:

Take-home income minus Fixed expenses minus Goal savings = money you can freely spend each month.

$

This is your real number. Write it on a sticky note.

Page 4 — Your Matched Budget Templates

Use the template that matches your quiz result. Skip the other two.

Template A — The Planner (Mostly C)

You want the full picture. Every category has a line. Adjust amounts to match your life.

Category	Budgeted $	Actual $
FIXED: Rent / Mortgage		
FIXED: Car payment / transport		
FIXED: Insurance (health, auto, renters)		
FIXED: Phone		
FIXED: Subscriptions (Netflix, Spotify, etc.)		
FIXED: Goal savings (from Page 3)		
VARIABLE: Groceries		
VARIABLE: Dining out / takeaway		
VARIABLE: Fuel / transit		
VARIABLE: Personal care / health		
VARIABLE: Clothing		
VARIABLE: Entertainment		
VARIABLE: Gifts / misc		
EMERGENCY BUFFER (10% of breathing room)		
TOTAL		

Template B — The Spender (Mostly B)

Fun money is a line item, not a reward. You allocate joy first, then cover the rest.

Category	Budgeted $	Actual $
FIXED: All fixed expenses (one lump total from Page 3)		
Goal savings (from Page 3)		
ENVELOPE 1: Groceries		
ENVELOPE 2: Fun money (dining, entertainment, shopping)		
ENVELOPE 3: Personal (care, clothing, health)		
ENVELOPE 4: Fuel / transit		
LEFTOVERS: Goes to savings or next month buffer		
TOTAL		

Template C — The Avoider (Mostly A)

One number. One rule. Check in once a week. That is it.

Your weekly spending limit:

Breathing room (from Page 3) divided by 4.3 = weekly limit

$ _____ per week

The only rule: spend less than this per week. Check your bank total on Sunday. Done.

Page 5 — Your 7-Day Starter Plan

One task per day. Max 10 minutes each. Tick the box when done.

☐ **Day 1**	Enter your numbers on Page 3. Calculate your breathing room. Write it down somewhere visible.
☐ **Day 2**	Fill in your matched budget template (Page 4). Use last month's bank statement to estimate variable amounts. Rough is fine.
☐ **Day 3**	Find and cancel one subscription you don't actively use. Add the savings to your goal line.
☐ **Day 4**	Set up one automatic transfer for your goal savings amount — even $25 counts. Schedule it for payday.
☐ **Day 5**	Do a 5-minute spending check. Open your bank app. Compare last week's spending against your template. No judgment, just awareness.
☐ **Day 6**	Read Page 6 (Budget Rescue). Identify your most likely failure point. Write it on the card.
☐ **Day 7**	Set a recurring 10-minute Sunday check-in on your phone. This single habit is worth more than any app.

Page 6 — The Budget Rescue Card (for when life happens)

This page is not for Day 1. It is for the day you fall off. Pull it out then.

If: "I overspent on food this week"

Food is emotional, social, and tied to energy. One bad week is not a broken budget. Go back to your weekly limit. Subtract what you overspent from next week's discretionary amount and move on.

Action: Check the difference. Reduce next week's eating-out envelope by that exact amount.

If: "An unexpected bill hit and wiped my budget"

Unexpected bills are not budget failures. They are why we build a buffer. If you have an emergency buffer line, use it. If not, reduce one variable category to cover it.

Action: Move money from the lowest-priority envelope this week. Replenish next month.

If: "I haven't checked in for 2+ weeks"

Starting again beats not starting. Open your bank app right now. Check your total spending against your breathing room number. Just that one check re-activates the system.

Action: Do the 5-minute check from Day 5. Then set next Sunday as your re-start.

If: "My partner/spouse isn't on board"

Forcing a budget on someone who resists it will kill it faster than overspending will. Start with one shared goal they care about. Show them the breathing room number. Let the number do the persuading.

Action: Ask them: what is one thing we could save for together? Build one shared line around their answer.

If: "I feel like this budget is too restrictive"

If your budget feels like deprivation, your categories are wrong — not your willpower. You have permission to move money between discretionary categories at any time.

Action: Revisit your breathing room number. Increase one category you care about by cutting one you don't.

Page 7 — Month 2 Bridge (after your first week)

Your first budget will be wrong. That is normal and expected. Here is how to fix it.

After week 1, check in on these three things:

Fix 1: Adjust over/under categories	Look at your template. Which categories did you consistently over-spend or underspend? Adjust the amounts to reflect reality, not intention. *Categories to adjust:*
Fix 2: Set one new micro-goal	Now that you can see your breathing room, what is one small additional thing you want to work toward? Add a $25-50/month line for it. *New micro-goal:*
Fix 3: Schedule your month 2 check-in	Pick a day in your calendar — 20 minutes — to review month 1 and set month 2's budget. This is the habit that makes everything compound. *Month 2 review date:*

You finished the 7-Day System.

Most people never make it past week 1. You did.

The budget you have now is not perfect. It is real. And real beats perfect every time.